

Climate, Wildlife, Animal Science, and Clean Tech

Climate, Wildlife, Animal Science, and Clean Tech: The Week of August 23-29, 2026

This week's throughline was infrastructure and enforcement — a presidential order restricting foreign equipment on the U.S. power grid, a running tally of court losses for the EPA's deregulatory push, and, on the conservation side, several hopeful stories of animals returning to the wild alongside a First Nations push to save a vanishing caribou herd. Sourcing is noted throughout, since several items rely on claims from advocacy groups, agencies, or single studies rather than settled fact.

Climate Policy

Trump bans some foreign-made grid equipment. On August 26, President Trump signed an emergency executive order declaring a national emergency over foreign-made electrical equipment on the U.S. bulk-power system. The order restricts acquisition, import, or installation of transformers, utility-scale inverters, battery storage systems, and related software tied to entities from roughly two dozen sanctioned or embargoed countries (coverage widely points to China as the practical target, though the order itself names no specific country). It applies only to equipment on transmission lines of 69kV or higher — not rooftop solar or local distribution — and covers deals “initiated” after August 26; the Department of Energy has 120 days to write implementing rules and can require removal of risky equipment already installed. Analysts note it builds on a 2020 Trump-era order that Biden suspended and never reinstated. It adds to a growing stack of federal restrictions on renewable-equipment supply chains this year, alongside an FCC ban on certain foreign inverters and existing solar tariffs.

A pattern of court losses for EPA rollbacks. A Bloomberg analysis published August 24 found that over the prior three months, federal courts ruled against the EPA in more than half of the cases challenging its attempts to roll back climate and air-quality rules — including a bid to weaken 2024 soot standards by asking a court to simply vacate them (rejected 3-0 by the D.C. Circuit in June) and several attempts to terminate billions in climate grants. EPA spokesperson Brigit Hirsch countered that the agency's wins get less attention, citing a July win on the \$7 billion Solar for All program on jurisdictional grounds. Attorney Jillian Blanchard of Lawyers for Good Government said “the tide feels like it is shifting.” The EPA has said it intends to appeal its loss on the \$20 billion Greenhouse Gas Reduction Fund case to the Supreme Court.

Wildlife & Conservation

A strong week for on-the-ground conservation work, alongside continuing U.S. policy fights:

- **Prescribed burns are saving giant sequoias.** A study circulating this week (via newsletter *Your Weekly Dose of Climate Hope*, Aug. 23) found sequoias treated with prescribed burns — the Indigenous practice of deliberately clearing underbrush with controlled fire — were roughly four times more likely to survive later wildfires. California’s 2020–21 fires killed nearly a fifth of all living giant sequoias; satellite analysis estimated prescribed burns directly saved about 1,900 trees.
- **Peccaries returned to a Costa Rican forest.** On August 27, Mongabay reported 13 white-lipped peccaries were released into Piedras Blancas National Park — the species’ first-ever reintroduction there, restoring a seed disperser whose absence had been felt throughout the forest’s ecology.
- **A marsupial breeding success in Australia.** On August 28, Mongabay reported a captive-insurance population of the endangered eastern quoll — extinct on mainland Australia since the 1960s — produced a new litter of joeys, a small but meaningful win for a recovery program built on captive breeding.
- **149 new deep-sea species** were reported discovered at remote seamounts near the Indian Ocean’s Cocos (Keeling) Islands (Mongabay, Aug. 26) — the kind of baseline survey that often precedes deep-sea mining or protection decisions.
- **A First Nations-led caribou petition.** On August 29, Mongabay reported First Nations in British Columbia’s Syilx Okanagan territory formally petitioned Canada for an emergency protection order for the southern mountain caribou; the Columbia North herd, the most viable of the territory’s three remaining herds, numbers only about 185 animals.
- **A photography milestone.** Joel Sartore’s Photo Ark project passed 18,000 documented species this week after 20 years photographing the world’s animals, many endangered, to build public support for conservation (Mongabay, Aug. 28).

U.S. legal fights over the Roadless Rule, grizzly bear habitat, the dunes sagebrush lizard, and California longline fishing permits remained unresolved this week, with no major new rulings identified.

Animal Health & Field Science

- **Bird feeders and bird flu risk.** ScienceDaily reported August 24 that experts are warning backyard bird feeders could become H5N1 transmission hotspots as Australia’s outbreak spreads, since feeders concentrate species that rarely interact in nature. Recommendations ranged from suspending feeding to cleaning feeders more often.
- **Human presence itself reshapes wildlife movement.** A large tracking study (ScienceDaily, Aug. 28) found the mere physical presence of people can redirect where wildlife moves, sometimes as strongly as roads or development. Species and sample-size details weren’t included in the summary reviewed, so this should be read as a notable but preliminary finding.
- **Chimpanzee behavior.** Some West African chimpanzees repeatedly throw rocks at particular trees, building stone piles that persist for over a decade — a behavior researchers still can’t fully explain (ScienceDaily, Aug. 28).

- **Genomic research.** A sweeping animal-genome analysis (ScienceDaily, Aug. 25) suggested chromosome evolution follows a limited number of largely irreversible patterns — basic science with potential relevance to how conservation genetics research interprets genetic diversity.

Clean Technology

- **Grid interconnection reform.** More than 50 GW of solar, wind, and battery projects can now connect to PJM, the mid-Atlantic/Midwest grid operator, following a queue reform (Canary Media, Aug. 24) — though realizing lower costs depends on follow-through from states, utilities, and data-center operators.
- **A new battery chemistry.** Australia's Flinders University demonstrated an aqueous zinc-iodine battery that sustained over 60,000 charge cycles in lab testing (ESS News, Aug. 27) — a cheaper, less flammable lithium-ion alternative for stationary storage, though lab results don't guarantee commercial timelines.
- **California's plug-in solar bill.** The state Assembly passed SB 868, the "Plug and Play Solar Act," simplifying permitting for small plug-in solar devices; as of Aug. 26 it awaited Senate concurrence before reaching the governor (pv magazine USA).
- **Data-center grid hardware.** Inverter maker SMA America expanded into data-center-focused grid infrastructure, aiming to help AI facilities skirt slow interconnection queues (pv magazine USA, Aug. 27).
- **Solar as heatwave resilience.** A newsletter roundup (*Your Weekly Dose of Climate Hope*, Aug. 23) described solar helping stabilize the European grid during 2026 heatwaves, as low river levels cut output from water-cooled coal, gas, and nuclear plants; cited figures (demand up to 25% higher, solar output up to 17% higher on peak days) come from a single secondary source and should be treated as approximate.

The Big Picture

This week's clean-tech and climate-policy stories were two sides of the same coin: the U.S. grid is being reshaped simultaneously by rapid renewable deployment and by new restrictions on where that hardware can come from, with real uncertainty about how the two forces net out. U.S. federal wildlife policy, meanwhile, stayed defined by litigation rather than agreement, even as courts have ruled against the administration more often than not. The most encouraging news came from outside U.S. federal policy entirely — peccaries in Costa Rica, sequoias surviving fire, a First Nations push for caribou protection, and new quoll joeys in Australia — a reminder that much of the most concrete conservation progress happens in reintroduction programs and Indigenous-led stewardship rather than courtrooms. None of this week's threads are resolved; most will likely reappear in the weeks ahead.

Sources

Grid equipment executive order: PV Tech, Energy-Storage.News, Utility Dive,

Al Jazeera, and Bloomberg coverage of the Aug. 26, 2026 order; pv magazine USA and Project Finance Law legal analyses (Norton Rose Fulbright).

EPA litigation: Insurance Journal (Bloomberg wire, Zahra Hirji), “Trump’s Environmental Rollbacks Are Being Struck Down by Courts,” Aug. 24, 2026; NRDC “White House Watch” tracker.

Wildlife & conservation: Your Weekly Dose of Climate Hope (Substack), sequoia prescribed-burn summary, Aug. 23; Mongabay: peccary release (Liz Kimbrough, Aug. 27), eastern quoll joeys (Paul Harvey, Aug. 28), deep-sea species discovery (Emma Smith, Aug. 26), Photo Ark milestone (Liz Kimbrough, Aug. 28), caribou petition (Ruth Kamnitzer, Aug. 29).

Animal health & field science: ScienceDaily — bird feeder/H5N1 warning (Aug. 24), human-presence wildlife study (Aug. 28), chimpanzee rock-throwing (Aug. 28), genome/chromosome evolution study (Aug. 25).

Clean technology: Canary Media, PJM interconnection reform (Jeff St. John, Aug. 24); ESS News, zinc-iodine battery (Aug. 27); pv magazine USA, SB 868 (Ben Zientara, Aug. 26) and SMA America (Ryan Kennedy, Aug. 27); Your Weekly Dose of Climate Hope, European heatwave solar summary (Aug. 23).

Note: A few items draw on secondary newsletter roundups (Your Weekly Dose of Climate Hope) rather than primary sources; flagged inline where it applies.